TypeLab usability test

Findings report · 2 October 2026 · Tested on the current `main` working tree

13	3	6	4
problems found	high severity	medium	low

Summary

TypeLab's core loop works: picking a style, changing it with sliders, saving and exporting a real font all succeeded. The style finder in particular is clear and well signposted. The biggest problems are about **where things are**, not whether they work:

- The editor doesn't fit screens narrower than about 1280 px, so Export is cut off on a 1024 px laptop and phones can't use it.
- A name change is lost if you leave without pressing Save, and every design starts out as "Untitled font".
- After you pick a style, nothing points to what to do next, and the glyph strip hides digits and punctuation off-screen.

All problems by severity

Severity	Problem	Where
High	1. The editor doesn't fit screens narrower than about 1280 px	Layout · all editor pages
High	2. A renamed design loses its new name when you leave	Saving · header
High*	3. Everyone using the same server shares one "My designs" list	Data · library
Medium	4. No clear next step after you pick a style	Style page · finder
Medium	5. The glyph strip hides numbers and punctuation off-screen	Glyph strip (bottom)
Medium	6. Designs end up nameless and hard to tell apart	Naming · library · export
Medium	7. Some filter chips are hard to read in their own typefaces	Style page · Filter panel
Medium	8. Letter-editing words and repeated controls are hard to follow	Inspector · Points mode
Medium	9. Tour cards cover the controls they describe	First-run guide
Low	10. Some labels in the Adjust tab are cut off	Style page · Adjust
Low	11. Exported file names run the words together	Export
Low	12. The opening splash shows on every new tab	Intro
Low	13. Delete and leave use the browser's plain pop-ups	Library · editor

High: blocks a task or loses work. **Medium**: slows users down or causes mistakes; they recover. **Low**: polish.

How the test was run

This was a **task-based expert walkthrough**: I worked through eight tasks as a first-time user would, in real Chrome, driven by script so every step and screenshot is reproducible. It was run against a private copy of the app with its own empty database, so your saved designs weren't touched.

#	Task	Result
1	First visit: watch the intro and take the guided tour	Done; the tour is clear but its cards cover what they point at
2	Find a serif style with "Help me choose" and start from it	Done in 3 clicks, then stuck: no next step
3	Type your own sample text and make the font bolder	Done
4	Inspect and customize one letter; try Points mode	Done; the wording is confusing
5	Save, rename, open My designs, duplicate	Rename was lost when leaving
6	Export the font file	Done; the file name runs the words together
7	Use the editor on a 1024 px laptop and a 390 px phone	Export cut off at 1024 px; can't be used on a phone
8	Keyboard and screen-reader basics	Labels and focus ring are good

Limits. No real participants took part. These findings come from an expert walkthrough plus a check of the code, not from watching users, so they show where people are *likely* to struggle. Confirm the high-severity items with 3–5 real users (e.g. typography students or designers new to type design) before investing heavily. Screen sizes tested: 1440 × 900, 1024 × 700 and 390 × 844 (phone emulation).

Problems in detail

1 The editor doesn’t fit screens narrower than about 1280 px

High

Layout · all editor pages

What happened

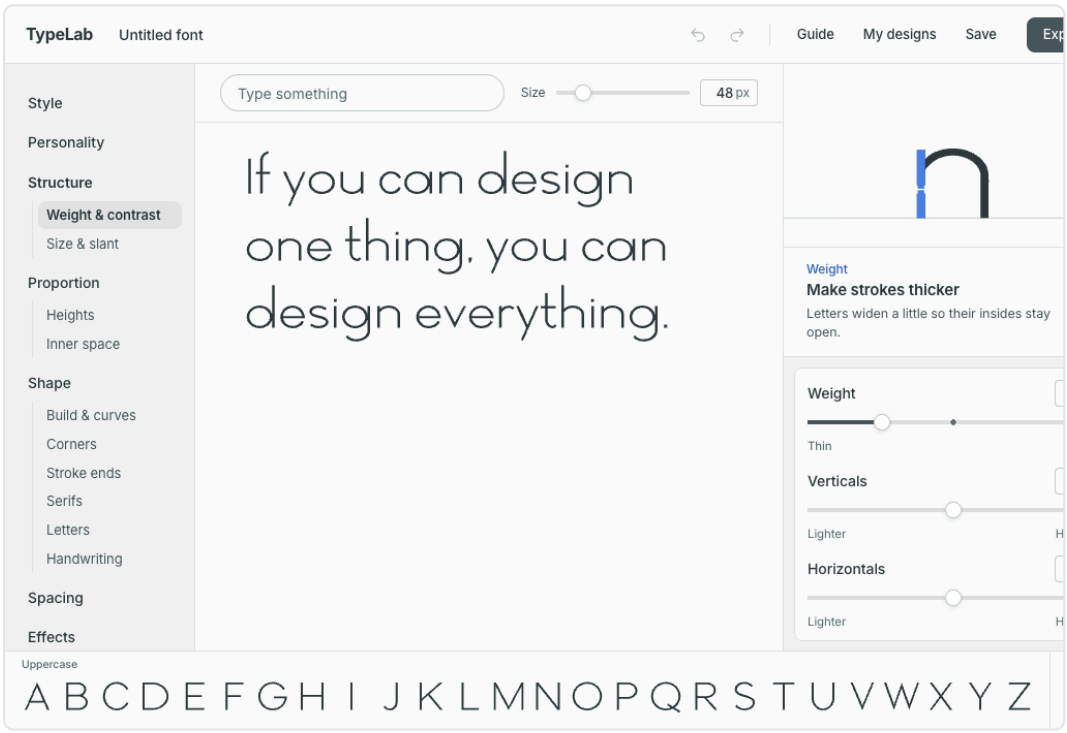
At 1024 × 700 (a small laptop or a tablet held sideways) the editor is wider than the window: the **Export** button is cut off at the right edge, and the right panel loses its value boxes and the “Bold / Heavier” slider labels. At phone width (390 px) you can see only the left menu and part of the preview. The style cards, the panel and the header are all off-screen.

Why it matters

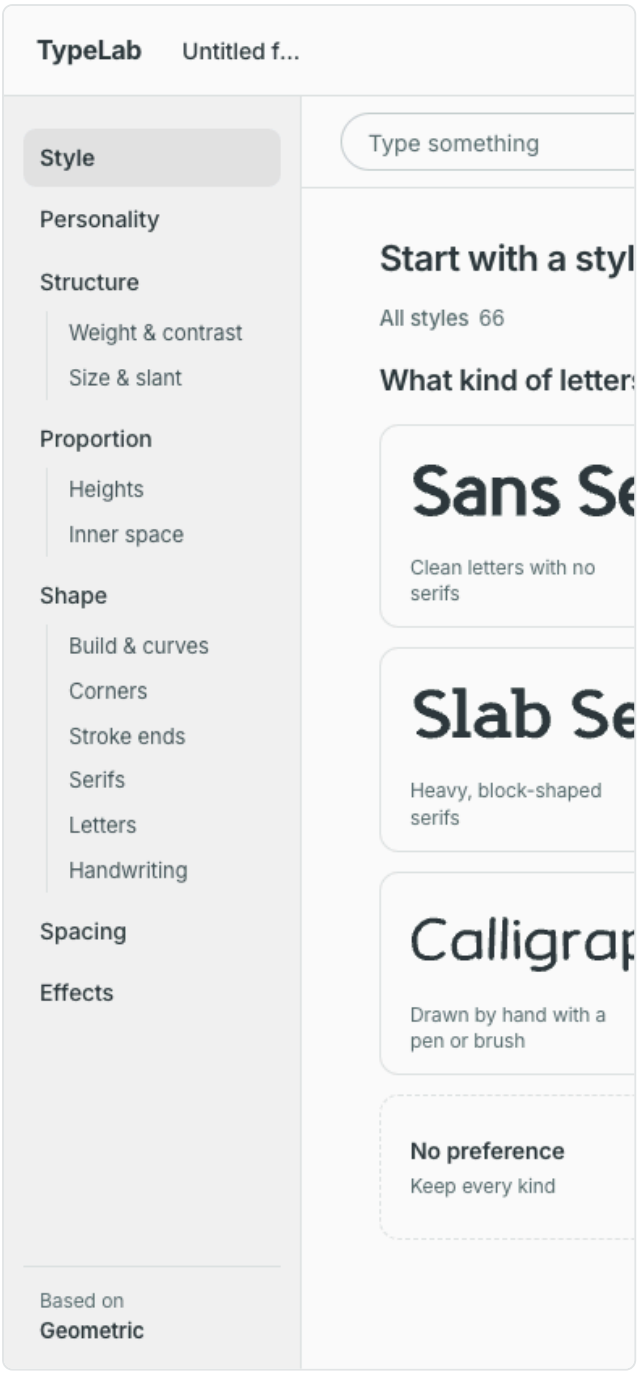
Export, the most important action, isn’t visible on common laptop sizes, and there’s no sign that the page scrolls sideways. On a phone the editor can’t be used. The My designs page does adapt, so a user can open a design there but then can’t edit it.

Suggested fix

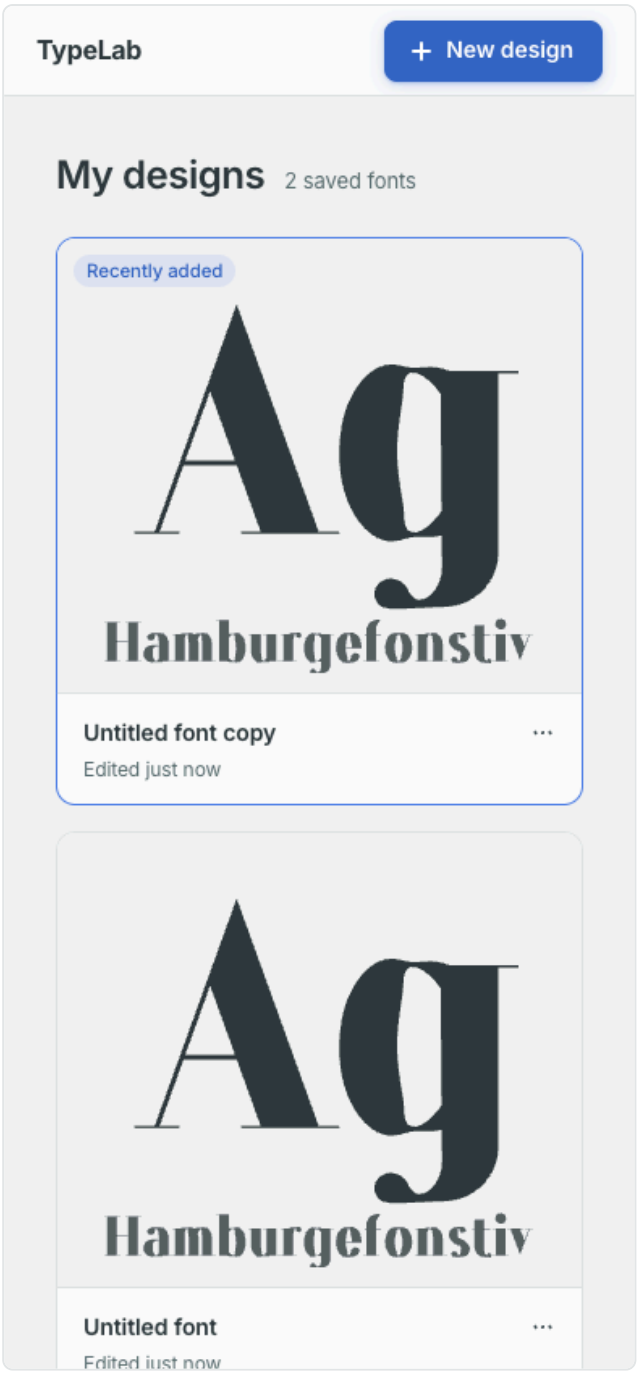
Below about 1200 px, let the left menu collapse into an icon rail or a menu button, and let the right panel overlay the preview or become a drawer. Keep Save and Export visible at every width. On phones, either show a “best on a larger screen” notice or offer a reduced layout with just preview + panel.



1024 × 700: the Export button and the right side of the panel are cut off



390 × 844 editor: only the menu and part of the preview fit



390 × 844 My designs: this page does adapt

2 A renamed design loses its new name when you leave

High

Saving · header

What happened

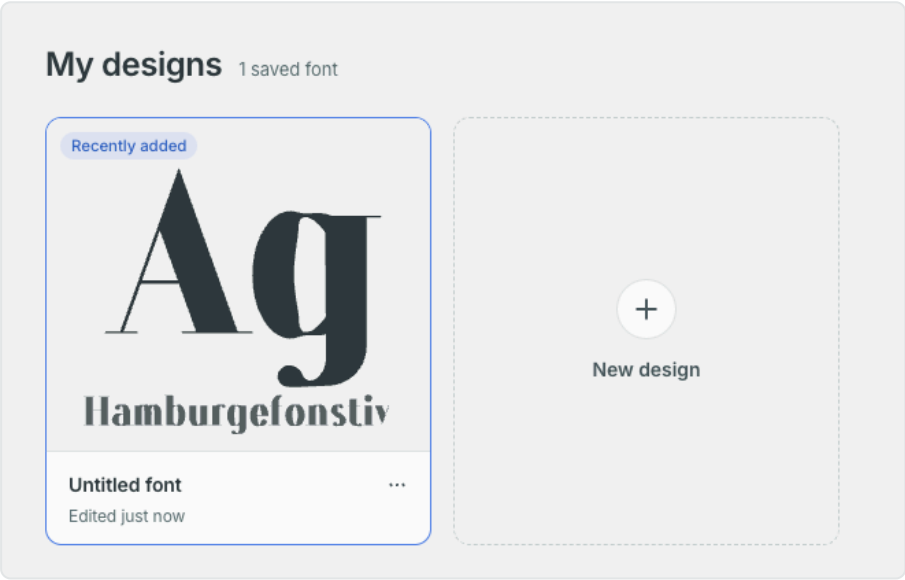
I saved a design, then renamed it “My Didone” in the name field and clicked **My designs**. The browser’s own dialog asked “You have unsaved changes. Leave without saving?” with only OK and Cancel. After OK, the library still listed the design as **“Untitled font”**, so the rename was thrown away.

Why it matters

Renaming feels like it saves itself, as file names do in most apps, so users don’t expect it to need Save. The dialog gives no way to save and leave, so the quickest answer loses work. Users only find out later, on the library page.

Suggested fix

Save a name change straight away for a design that has been saved before. Replace the browser dialog with an in-app one: **Save and leave · Leave without saving · Stay**.



After renaming to “My Didone” and leaving, the card still says “Untitled font”

3 Everyone using the same server shares one “My designs” list

High*

Data · library

What happened

The designs table has no owner or account column (`server/db.ts`), and the API returns every design to every visitor. The page is titled **My designs**, but on a shared deployment anyone can open, duplicate or delete anyone else’s fonts.

Why it matters

The label promises the designs are private. On a hosted copy, one visitor could delete another person’s work, and the delete can’t be undone. **This only matters once the site is hosted for more than one person. It doesn’t affect a local install.*

Suggested fix

Before sharing the site publicly, scope designs to a user, even just an anonymous browser ID stored in a cookie. Otherwise rename the page to something like “All designs on this server”.

4 No clear next step after you pick a style

Medium

Style page · finder

What happened

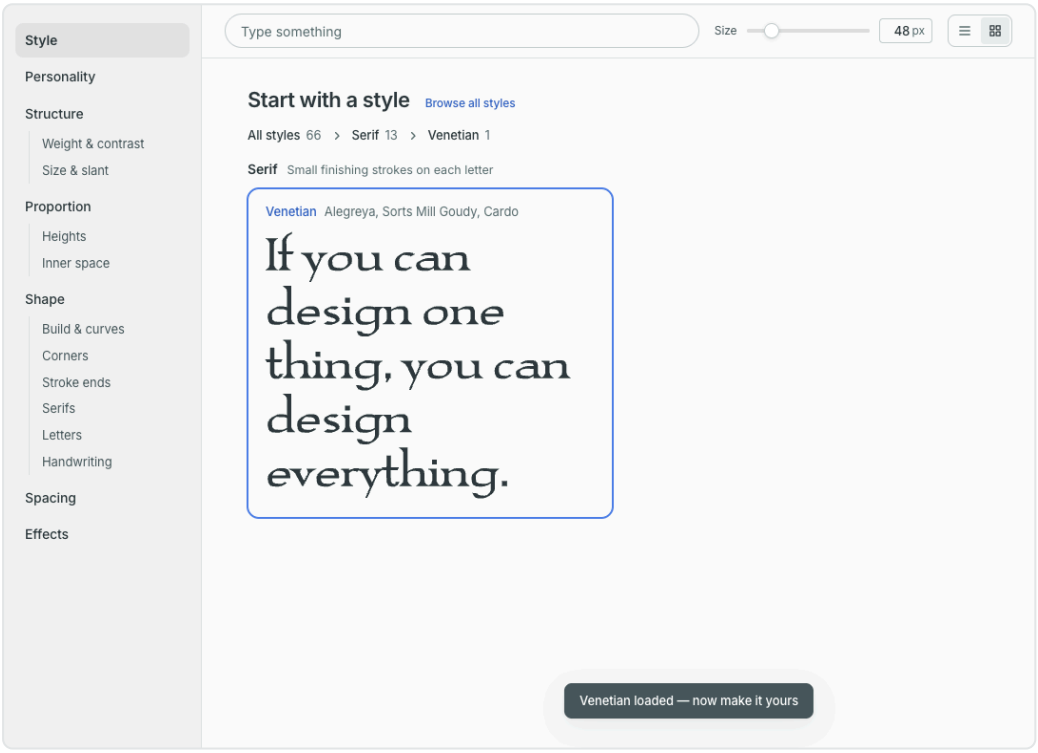
With **Help me choose** I answered “Serif” → “Venetian”, which left one card. Clicking it showed a toast, “Venetian loaded — now make it yours”, but I stayed on the Style page and nothing pointed to where to make it mine. The 14 pages in the left menu (Personality, Structure, Proportion, Shape…) aren’t signposted.

Why it matters

First-time users have just made their first decision and stall. They have to guess that the left menu is the way forward and which of its 14 entries to open first.

Suggested fix

After a style is picked, show a clear next step on the card or beneath the results, such as **“Customize this style →”** opening Personality, or a short “Next: shape its personality” banner. Mark the menu entries a beginner should try first.



After picking Venetian: a toast appears, but the page stays the same and there’s no call to action

5 The glyph strip hides numbers and punctuation off-screen

Medium

Glyph strip (bottom)

What happened The strip along the bottom is 3,147 px wide inside a 1,440 px window. Only A–Z and a–k are visible, and the scrollbar is 1 px tall, so it effectively doesn't show. Nothing tells you that lowercase l–z, Figures and Punctuation are further along.

Why it matters Users who want to check or customize a digit or "&" can't find them and may think the font only has letters. The strip only moves when you open a letter in the inspector, which scrolls it.

Suggested fix Add left/right scroll buttons or a fade at the edge, and make the group labels (Uppercase · Lowercase · Figures · Punctuation) a row of jump links. Alternatively, wrap the strip into two rows or let it be opened into a full glyph grid.



At 1440 px the strip ends at "k": Figures and Punctuation are out of sight

6 Designs end up nameless and hard to tell apart

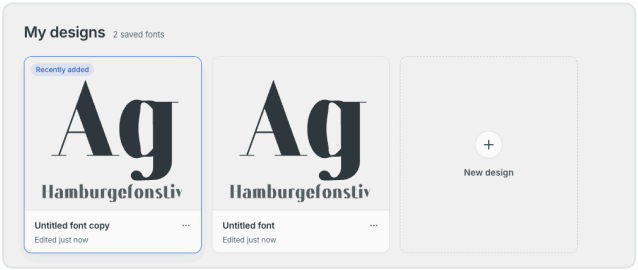
Medium

Naming · library · export

What happened Save never asks for a name, so every design is saved as **"Untitled font"**, and duplicates as "Untitled font copy". The name field in the header looks like plain text: transparent border, no pencil or "Rename" hint. The library card menu has only Duplicate and Delete, not Rename. Export then names the file `Untitledfontcopy.otf` because spaces are dropped (see the next issue).

Why it matters After a few sessions the library is a wall of identical titles that can only be told apart by their previews. The installed font is also called "Untitled font" in Word, Figma and other apps.

Suggested fix On first Save, open a small "Name your font" field, filled in with the style name, e.g. "Venetian Custom". Show a pencil icon or underline when you hover over the name. Add **Rename** to the library card menu.



Library after one save and one duplicate



The header name field looks like a label, not an input

7 Some filter chips are hard to read in their own typefaces

Medium

Style page · Filter panel

What happened

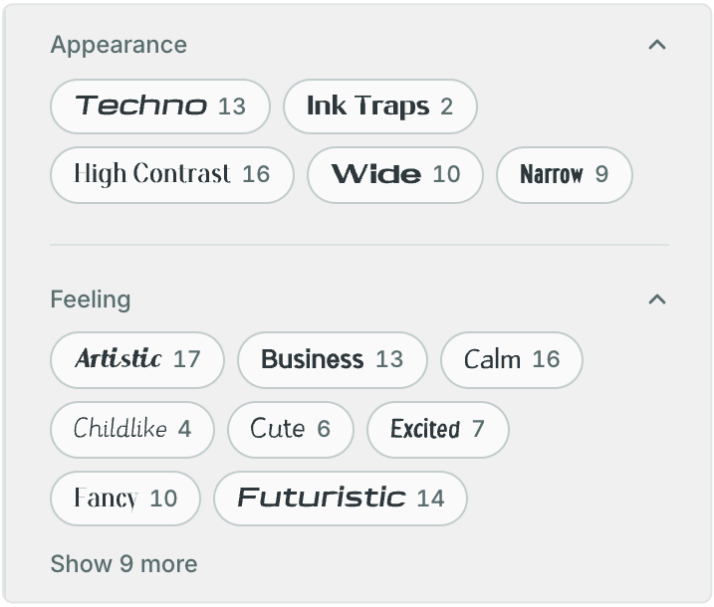
Each filter chip is drawn in a matching typeface. Several are hard to read at chip size: **Fancy** reads as “lancy” because the F’s arm is a hairline, and **High Contrast** loses the H crossbar. Childlike and Artistic need a second look. Chips that match no styles are drawn in light grey on a light grey background.

Why it matters

Filter labels exist to be scanned quickly. When a label can’t be read, users skip the filter or pick the wrong one, and the faint zero-count chips are hard to read at all.

Suggested fix

Keep the decorative typeface for a small sample (e.g. an “Aa” swatch) and write the label itself in Inter. Or keep the typeface but set a minimum stroke weight at chip size. Make zero-count chips meet 4.5:1 contrast, or hide them.



Zoomed (2×): “Fancy” and “High Contrast” lose strokes at chip size

8 Letter-editing words and repeated controls are hard to follow

Medium

Inspector · Points mode

What happened

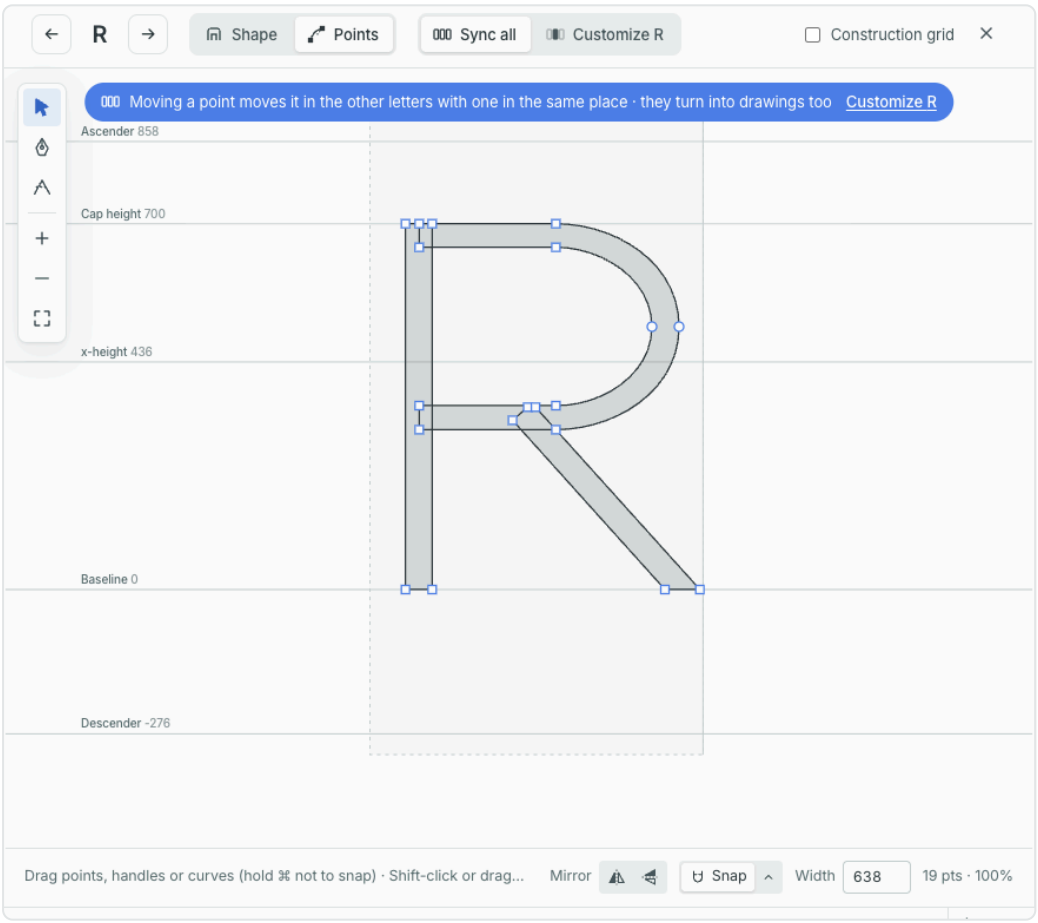
In Points mode a blue banner over the canvas reads “Moving a point moves it in the other letters with one in the same place · they turn into drawings too”. The help line at the bottom is cut off mid-sentence (“…Shift-click or drag…”). **Sync all / Customize R** appears twice, in the inspector toolbar and again in the panel (“Each stroke · Customize R”).

Why it matters

Non-designers don’t know what “turn into drawings” means, or that it switches the letter off from every slider. A cut-off help line hides the keyboard shortcuts it’s there to teach. Two Customize buttons make users wonder whether they do different things.

Suggested fix

Rewrite the banner in plain words, e.g. *“Editing points here also changes matching points in other letters. Edited letters stop following the sliders.”* Let the help line wrap or move it behind a “?” popover. Keep one Customize control, or label the second one for what it does differently.



Points mode: the jargon banner on top, the cut-off help line at the bottom

9 Tour cards cover the controls they describe

Medium

First-run guide

What happened

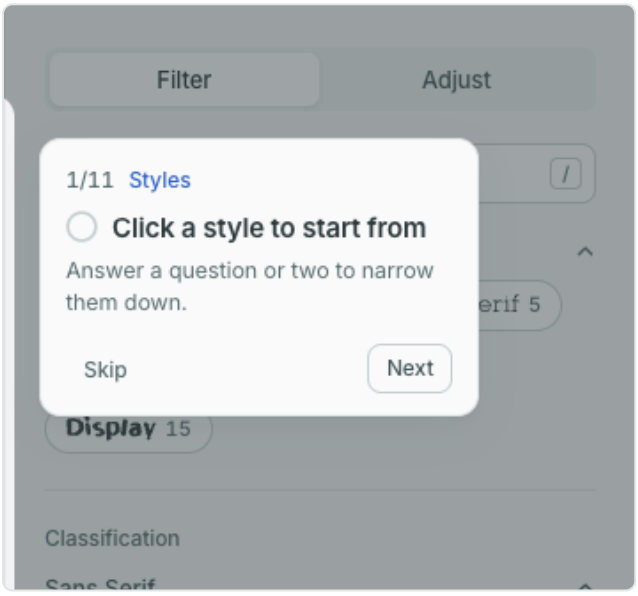
In several steps the tour card sits on top of the area it’s pointing at. Step 1 (“Click a style”) covers the search box and Category chips. Step 3 (“Pick a trait”) covers the Size control. Step 11 covers the panel’s heading. Each step can also be passed with **Next** without trying the task.

Why it matters

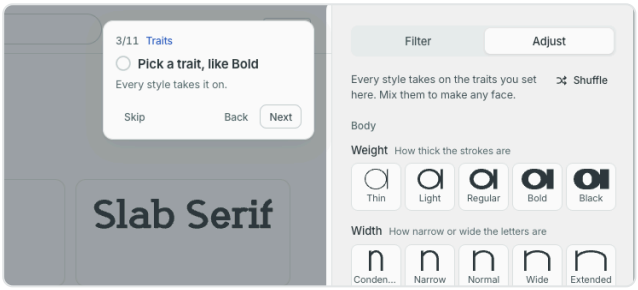
In a hands-on tour, hiding the controls you’re asked to use is confusing. Users click Next to get the card out of the way and miss the lesson.

Suggested fix

Place the card wherever it overlaps the spotlight least (try every side and pick the best), or let it be dragged. Consider a softer nudge, such as “Try it first”, when Next is pressed before the task is done.



Step 1: the card hides the search box and Category chips



Step 3: the card sits over the Size control

10 Some labels in the Adjust tab are cut off

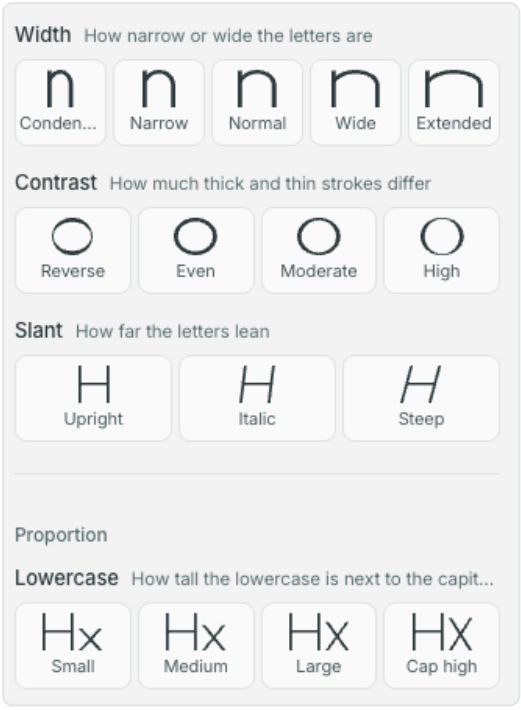
Low

Style page · Adjust

What happened Trait tiles and descriptions are cut off with "…": **"Conden…"** (Condensed) and "How tall the lowercase is next to the capit…".

Why it matters This is minor, but the cut-off words are the ones that explain the option.

Suggested fix Let the tile labels and descriptions wrap onto a second line, or move the description under the heading, so nothing is cut off.



"Conden…" and the cut-off Lowercase description

11 Exported file names run the words together

Low

Export

What happened The file name drops every space and symbol: "My Didone" becomes `MyDidone.otf`, "Untitled font copy" becomes `Untitledfontcopy.otf` (`shared/design.ts`, `slug()`).

Why it matters The names are harder to read in Downloads and in the font installer.

Suggested fix Replace spaces with hyphens instead of dropping them: `My-Didone.otf`.

12 The opening splash shows on every new tab

Low

Intro

What happened The TypeLab title card plays for about 2.3 s each time a new browser tab opens (it's remembered for the tab, not the browser). It can be skipped with a click or a key, but nothing says so.

Why it matters Returning users opening a design in a new tab wait every time.

Suggested fix Show it once per browser (localStorage), or only on the first visit.

13 Delete and leave use the browser's plain pop-ups

Low

Library · editor

What happened	Deleting a design and leaving with unsaved changes both use `window.confirm`. Delete says "This can't be undone", and there's no undo afterwards either.
Why it matters	The pop-ups don't look like the rest of the app, can't offer a third choice (see the rename issue), and one wrong click permanently deletes a font.
Suggested fix	Use in-app dialogs, and for Delete show a toast with **Undo** for a few seconds before actually deleting.

What worked well

- **Help me choose.** The finder asks one question at a time, shows how many styles each answer keeps, and keeps a breadcrumb trail (All styles 66 › Serif 13 › Venetian 1), so you always know where you are and can go back.
- **Empty and error states.** A search with no results says "No styles match these filters" with a Clear link. A deleted design and an unknown address each get a clear page with a way back.
- **Feedback.** Every save, export, duplicate and delete shows a short toast. Save shows a dot while there are unsaved changes. Undo/redo work from both the buttons and ⌘Z / ⇧⌘Z.
- **Accessibility basics.** Every button and input on the editor has an accessible name: 0 unnamed buttons and 0 unlabelled inputs found. The keyboard focus ring is a clear 2 px blue outline.
- **Export works.** Export → Font file produced a real .otf download within about 3 s, with a toast saying how to install it.
- **The library.** My designs previews each font in its own letters, marks the latest one, and adapts to phone width.

Suggested order of fixes

- **First:** #2 (save a renamed design straight away; in-app leave dialog) and #1 (make the editor fit narrower screens; keep Export visible).
- **Next:** #4 (a next-step button after choosing a style), #5 (glyph strip navigation) and #6 (ask for a name on first save; Rename in the library). These are small changes that make a first session much easier.
- **Before hosting publicly:** #3 (designs per user).
- **Polish:** #7–#13.